

PRODUCT DOCUMENTATION

Work About Work

Diagnostic Question Bank

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Version	1.1 (em dashes removed throughout)
Status	Draft
Companion to	Framework Document v1.1 / Calculator Methodology v1.1
Audience	Internal: product, consulting, content

01

Purpose of This Document

This document is the authoritative record of the five diagnostic questions used in the Work About Work audit tool. For each question it documents: the process dimension being measured, the sequencing rationale, the four answer options, the score assigned to each, and what that score signals about the team's coordination health.

This document is the source of truth for anyone building, modifying, or extending the audit. No question or score should be changed in the tool without a corresponding update [here](#).

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Design Principles

Symptom to cause

Questions move from what is observable (meeting types, frequency) to what causes it (decision ownership, process maturity). A respondent who answers honestly reveals the root cause by the end, even if they do not recognise it.

Five questions maximum

The tool is a lead magnet. It must complete in under 90 seconds. Five questions is the ceiling: enough to produce a credible score, short enough to maintain completion rates.

Four options per question

Each question offers four options to avoid the "middle choice" bias of three-option scales. There is no neutral answer: every option carries diagnostic signal.

Total score drives output

The five scores sum to a single Process Defect Score (0–15). That score determines the output band and the three recommendations. Individual question scores are not surfaced to the user: only the total.

Conservative scoring direction

Score 0 always represents the healthiest answer. Score 3 always represents the highest-defect answer. Higher score means more process friction.

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Scoring Overview

Each question is scored 0–3. The five scores are summed to produce a Process Defect Score between 0 and 15. The score maps to one of three output bands.

Score range	Band	What it means	Output
0–4	Healthy	Good process hygiene across most dimensions. Optimisation opportunity, not systemic redesign.	3 optimisation recommendations
5–9	Moderate	Clear friction points in 2–3 dimensions. Targeted interventions will produce measurable gains.	3 targeted fix recommendations
10–15	High Risk	Systemic coordination defect across most dimensions. Structural redesign required.	3 systemic redesign recommendations

Note: The score bands are deliberately asymmetric. Healthy occupies a narrow range (0–4) because genuinely low-friction teams are rare. Most knowledge-work organisations will score in the Moderate or High Risk band: this is consistent with the empirical baseline (16.4 hrs/week on coordination overhead) in the Framework Document.

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The Five Questions

Each question is documented in full below: the process lever it measures, its role in the symptom-to-cause sequence, the question text as it appears in the tool, and the full scoring rationale for each of the four answer options.

Q1

PROCESS LEVER: MEETING DESIGN

Symptom: What is most visible about how the team spends its time

What best describes the majority of your team's recurring meetings?

Why this question: Meeting type is the most visible symptom of coordination overhead. Status-update meetings are the clearest signal of a reporting-over-deciding culture: the defining characteristic of high-defect teams.

Score	Answer option	What it signals
0	Deep work sessions or workshops	Meetings are used for creation and problem-solving, not information transfer. Low defect signal.
1	Decision-making with clear owners	Meetings have a purpose and an accountable outcome. Moderate health: some overhead still present.
2	Alignment meetings: getting everyone on the same page	Alignment meetings often mask unclear ownership. Recurring alignment is a structural signal, not a one-off.
3	Status updates: reporting what happened	The highest-defect pattern. Status can almost always be moved to async. If it is not, it signals absent process infrastructure.

Q2

PROCESS LEVER: MEETING STRUCTURE

First structural cause: Does the team prepare for meetings, or just attend them?

How often do meetings have a written agenda shared in advance?

Why this question: Agenda discipline is the first proxy for process maturity. Teams that default to unstructured meetings are implicitly accepting that meetings exist for social coordination, not decision-making. It is a leading indicator of time waste, not a lagging one.

Score	Answer option	What it signals
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0	Always: it's a team norm	Agendas are infrastructure, not effort. Indicates a culture where meeting time is treated as a resource to protect.
1	Usually, but not consistently	Process awareness exists but has not been systematised. Improvement is accessible with low effort.
2	Sometimes: for big meetings only	Agendas are reserved for high-stakes situations, implying low-stakes meetings are unstructured by default.
3	Almost never	No agenda culture. Every meeting is improvised. High overhead, low accountability, low decision velocity.

Q3

PROCESS LEVER: ASYNC MATURITY

Could the symptom be avoided? Testing whether meetings are the only option

Could the majority of your information-sharing meetings be replaced by an async message instead?

Why this question: This question tests the team's awareness of alternatives to synchronous coordination. A team that recognises most of its meetings could be async but has not made that change has a process design problem, not an information problem. A team that genuinely needs live discussion is structurally healthier.

Score	Answer option	What it signals
0	No: the live discussion adds real value	Synchronous time is used deliberately. Meetings create value that async cannot replicate.
1	Some, but not most	Partial async awareness. Some meetings are already substitutable; others are defended on legitimate grounds.
2	Probably most of them	High substitutability with low action taken. Indicates process inertia: the meetings continue because stopping them requires effort.
3	Yes, almost all of them	The team is aware its meetings are redundant but has not redesigned. Maximum defect signal: the overhead is visible and unaddressed.

Q4

PROCESS LEVER: DECISION ARCHITECTURE

Root cause: Who owns decisions, and is that clear before the meeting starts?

When you leave a meeting, how often is there a clear owner and next action?

Why this question: Decision clarity is the root cause beneath meeting overload. When ownership is unclear, decisions recur across meetings. When next actions are undocumented, follow-up meetings replace the action itself. This question identifies whether the team has a decision architecture or relies on social memory.

Score	Answer option	What it signals
0	Almost always: we have a clear system	Decision infrastructure exists. Meetings produce outcomes, not just discussions. Low defect.
1	Usually, but follow-through is inconsistent	Decisions are made but not systematically tracked. The gap is in execution, not process design.
2	Sometimes: varies by meeting	Inconsistent ownership signals ad hoc decision-making. No reliable system: outcomes depend on individual initiative.
3	Rarely: things feel discussed but not decided	The highest-defect pattern. Meetings are social rather than functional. Decisions recirculate, creating the next round of meetings.

Q5

PROCESS LEVER: AI AND WORKFLOW MATURITY

The lever: What capacity exists to improve the system?

How is your team currently using AI tools to reduce admin and coordination work?

Why this question: AI adoption is placed last because it is the improvement lever, not the diagnosis. A team scoring high on Q1–Q4 has a process defect. This question establishes how equipped they are to address it. Low AI adoption in a high-defect team indicates the highest reclaim potential and the clearest consulting opportunity.

Score	Answer option	What it signals
0	We have consistent team-wide AI workflows	AI is systematised, not experimental. Coordination overhead is already being actively reduced.

1	We have some shared workflows but no system	Partial adoption. The potential is recognised but not yet operationalised at team level.
2	A few individuals are experimenting	Isolated adoption. No shared benefit. Risk of AI increasing inequality within the team rather than reducing overhead.
3	We are not using AI for this at all	Maximum reclaim potential. Combined with high scores on Q1–Q4, this is the clearest signal for intervention.

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Why This Sequence

The questions are ordered to take the respondent on a diagnostic journey without them realising it. By the end, they have implicitly diagnosed their own team.

Q	Lever	Role in sequence
1	Meeting Design	Opens with the most observable symptom. Anyone can answer this immediately: low cognitive load, high engagement.
2	Meeting Structure	Moves from what meetings are to how they are run. Introduces the idea that structure (or its absence) drives the symptom.
3	Async Maturity	Tests whether the respondent recognises there are alternatives. Creates mild cognitive dissonance in high-defect teams.
4	Decision Architecture	Surfaces the root cause. By now the respondent is primed to connect unclear ownership to the meeting patterns they described in Q1–Q3.
5	AI and Workflow Maturity	Ends with the lever. Positions AI as the solution to the problem they have just diagnosed themselves. Creates the "I need help with this" moment.

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Reserved Questions for Future Versions

The following dimensions were considered for v1.0 and excluded to maintain the 90-second completion target. They are documented here for future development.

Dimension	Why excluded from v1.0	Future potential
Tool fragmentation	Requires context about tech stack: too specific for a general lead magnet	Strong for enterprise audit mode in v2.0
Cross-team coordination overhead	Adds complexity beyond a single team's scope	Relevant for programme-level diagnostics
Documentation culture	Overlaps with async maturity (Q3) at this level of resolution	Could replace Q3 in a deeper audit version